How to Make a Guide

Understanding the Guide

1.1 Decide the Range of the Guide

Understand what level the guide is meant for:

- Beginner guides need clear, step-by-step instructions,
- Intermediate guides can assume some prior knowledge, and
- In-depth guides should include explanations and reasoning for flexibility.

This decides how detailed the guide should be and how much you need to explain.

1.2 Avoid Vague Instructions

Try to be specific instead of general.

- Mention exact steps
- Specify what to click, select, or change
- Avoid statements that can be interpreted in multiple ways

Clarity matters more than wording.

1.3 Choose the Theme Based on Usage

- Both light and dark themes are effective, but their suitability depends on context.
- Dark theme is not ideal for printing, while light theme works better for printed guides.
- For digital or soft-copy use, especially in software-related guides, dark theme fits well as it matches the screen environment.
- For general use, light theme is more flexible and often preferred for readability.

1.4 Decide How Much Guidance to Provide

- Understand how much "spoonfeeding" the guide requires based on the audience.
- You can structure it with more text and fewer visuals, fewer text and more visuals, or a balanced mix of both.
- Visuals can be enhanced by adding circles to highlight key areas, arrows to indicate direction, and numbered steps within images.
- Ultimately, choose the approach that makes the process easiest to understand and follow.

2. Making the Guide

2.1 Start with the Content

- Begin by writing everything in text form before focusing on design.
- Clearly list all steps, add explanations where necessary, and maintain a logical flow from start to finish.
- Avoid jumping into formatting or visuals at this stage.
- A practical approach is to first complete the content, then refine, organize, and structure it afterward as needed..

2.2 Use Tools that Support Your Workflow

- Choose tools that make structuring and designing easier.
    - Tools like Canva can be used to visually design and arrange the guide, while text editors or AI tools can help refine and organize the content.
    - Use these tools to improve clarity and presentation, but not as a substitute for your own thinking and understanding.

2.3 Break Content into Sections

- Once the content is ready, divide it into clear steps and group related actions together.
- Align each section with where visuals will be placed so the structure supports easy understanding.
- Ensure that every section represents one distinct part of the process, making the guide simple and organized to follow.

2.4 Add Visuals Where Needed

- Place visuals based on clarity rather than decoration.
- Add relevant screenshots or references and ensure each visual matches the correct step. Keep visuals aligned closely with the corresponding text so they support understanding.
- Enhance them when needed by highlighting important areas, showing where to focus, and clearly indicating the flow of actions.

2.5 Add Minimal Design Support

- Keep the design simple and functional by maintaining proper spacing and alignment, and using consistent layouts throughout.
- Avoid adding unnecessary elements that may clutter the guide. The design should support and enhance the content, not distract from it.

2.6 Maintain Flow

- Review the guide step by step to ensure the sequence makes sense, with no missing steps or sudden jumps. Each step should flow naturally into the next, creating a smooth and easy-to-follow process.

3. Final Check

3.1 Refine the Guide

- Simplify complex sentences, remove unnecessary words, and keep all instructions clear and direct for easy understanding.

3.2 Keep the Intent Clear

- The purpose of the guide is to help users complete a task efficiently. Ensure it remains usable, clear, and well-structured throughout.

Final Flow

This guide was designed as a purely text-based, "read and understand" guide rather than a visual-heavy one. The idea is to study other guides, understand their structure, and then try creating your own. Most of my PDF guides were created for separate repositories and specific purposes. A few of my guides can be found here:
Github.com > Runarok > Guides > Code Manual > Softwares.